



FORGET BAD BOYS: THE **MEN** ARE HERE

You're Marcus Fenix. A former COG (Coalition of Organised Governments), now declared traitor, serving sentence. The game starts with you being rudely busted out of the can by some of your former teammates. Battling your way out of the jail pens, killing locusts (what else?). Your aim at this point is to rendezvous with one Alpha squad who are in possession of an unknown artefact of immense power.

Its 14 days after Emergence Day—the day the locust horde first emerged from the bowels of the Earth; their mission the obliteration of humanity; reason unknown... Incidentally, these locusts are humanoid, with the same weapons you have, and they can use 'em too! The locust army has a number of variants—you'll go up against Drones, Hunters, Berserkers, Boomers to name a few...

What will strike you first is that the action is fast, furiously so. Tactics are of paramount importance—you cannot achieve anything with blazing guns alone. Cover and how you manoeuvre around it is perhaps the most important skill you will need to learn, headshots notwithstanding... You are as vulnerable as your enemies, and peeking around corners will cause others to take potshots at you, while your intended target lays low. Cover, cover, cover...I've said it before...I'm saying it again!

You move as an individual, covering your squad mates as they cover you: every hunk of concrete is tactically significant, as is every corner. Death lurks in abundance in every splendidly-done level of GOW, and your wits are the only thing you've got going for you.

Graphically brilliant, the combat ultra-realistic and 100 per cent brutal... you will frequently see oodles of gore on-screen. By gore we don't

mean just bullet holes in corpses and splattering skulls via headshots, but actual chainsaw action courtesy the ripper—an assault rifle with a (you guessed it) chainsaw melee attachment. Then you can actually melee an enemy with a grenade (these grenades have spikes that penetrate armour and hide...ouch! Clinging to the baddie while he jumps around, the grenade will explode after five seconds...splat! The storyline, while not the deepest I've seen, is good enough not to cause an "Aw, I knew that would happen."

One of the biggest pluses for GOW is its control system. Initially difficult to control, GOW is perhaps the best third-person implementation on the X360 to date. Camera angles don't disappoint either. Just as well. GOW punishes all but the most observant of COGs.

Did I mention GOW's multiplayer rocks? This game has been touted as a console seller, promising to do for the X360 what *Halo* did for the X-Box!

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**GEARS
OF WAR**

Rating: 9/10
Developer: Epic Games
Publisher: Microsoft Game Studios
Distributor: xxxx
Contact: xxx
Price: Rs x,xxx
Platform: Xbox 360